

The Policy in the Room

POSC 459 — Social Welfare Politics and Policy

Week 2 · Wednesday, September 2

Howard ch. 2, "Tracks of My Tiers" · Desmond ch. 2

Today

1. **Research pre-survey** (~10 min)
2. **PapyrusAI sign-up**, everyone, in the room (~10 min)
3. My AI policy, briefly — then the \$13M one behind it (~20 min)
4. **Howard's tiers and Desmond's flatline** (~30 min)

First: the pre-survey

uci.questionpro.com/t/Acs2vZ9boH

- It is **part of a research study**, and it is **voluntary**.
- No credit either way. Declining costs you nothing with me.
- Absent today, or want to do it later? Complete it on your own **by Friday 9/11**.

Sign-up, together, now

1. Canvas course nav → **PapyrusAI**. First access **creates your account**.
2. Choose Google or a password — decide now, not in October.
3. Course code: **FALL2026-POSC459**
4. Confirm you're enrolled before you close the tab.

One entry, one new conversation.

The + button. Top right. Every time.

Five AI policies, and one of them is mine

- Five courses, five sets of rules, and you are expected to hold all of them straight. **16 of 25** of you said so on the Check-In.
- That is **administrative burden**, and I am contributing to it. Week 3 gives you the vocabulary.
- Mine is §12 of the syllabus, plus the long version on Canvas. **Read it before the first Yellow assignment.** Not now.
- Standing invitation: find me the line where a reasonable student would get it wrong, and I will fix it.

My stake, on the record

- I use these tools.
- I'm in a grant-funded faculty learning community promoting AI-integrated teaching.
- This course runs on PapyrusAI.

Asking you to evaluate something I benefit from without saying so would be the exact failure the disclosure rule exists to prevent.

Scale it up

The CSU–OpenAI contract.

- 2025: systemwide ChatGPT Edu, ~\$17M for eighteen months — announced by the [Chancellor's Office](#) and by [OpenAI](#).
- Renewed May 2026: **~\$13M a year, for three years**, 675,000 users ([EdSource](#)).
- Sold as *equitable access*. Contested in public: [LAist](#) on the \$2.3B budget gap, [CalMatters](#) on who refuses to use it, the [AAUP](#) on whom it serves.

You have an account because of this decision.

Contested in public

Who	What	When
CSU Chancellor's Office	CSU Announces Landmark Initiative to Become Nation's First and Largest AI-Empowered University System	Feb 2025
LAist	Inside Cal State's big \$17 million bet on ChatGPT for all	Aug 2025
LAist	Why did the CSU spend millions on ChatGPT amid a budget crisis? We asked school leaders	Aug 2025
AAUP	Cal State's War on Working-Class Education (Lincoln and Kenney)	Spring 2026
CalMatters	Cal State struck a deal with OpenAI. Some students and faculty refuse to use it	May 2026
EdSource	California State University renews controversial systemwide contract with OpenAI	May 2026

Circle up — six minutes

Turn to the **three or four people around you**. Nobody moves a chair.

Pick **one**:

1. Does "**equitable access**" describe what the contract does? What would have to be true for the claim to hold?
2. **Who bears the cost** — and is it the group that gets the benefit?
3. **You were not consulted**. Compare: how are TANF or SNAP recipients consulted — or not?

Bring back **a position** and the strongest argument against it. A circle that reports both sides goes back for one minute.

Before we leave it — a poll

Does receiving something make you more likely to defend the decision that provided it?

That question has a name

Policy feedback. Once made, a policy builds its own constituency and sets the terms of the next fight. Paul Pierson, "When Effect Becomes Cause" — Week 4.

You just ran the drill on a policy you are inside of. **Discussion Paper 1** asks you to run it on someone else's:

Pick one person or moment from *Growing Up Poor in America* and one claim from Howard ch. 3 or Pierson. Say what the film does to the claim — illustrates it, complicates it, or contradicts it. Then decide: is this a policy-feedback story, and if so, which policy?

Due **Friday 9/18**, 11:59 p.m., on Canvas. Part 2 of the film comes in Week 4.

Monday I left you a question

If poverty is a knot and not a line — what number would tell us we're making progress?

Before the number: **the map**. Howard's chapter is about which programs we count, and how we sort them.

Howard's map: the two tiers

Upper tier — "social insurance"	Lower tier — "welfare"
Social Security · Medicare · Disability Insurance · Unemployment Insurance · Workers' compensation	Medicaid · the EITC · SSI · TANF · Food Stamps (SNAP) · Public housing and Section 8

The textbook story: the upper tier is **larger, more generous, more uniform, more popular, and harder to cut**. The lower tier is the one Americans say they hate.

Which of these has someone in this room, or their family, used?

Cracks in the tiers

- **Same family, same program, same year.** TANF, family of three, 2002: **\$201** a month in Texas, **\$636** in Connecticut.
- **Same hand.** Lose it on the job: up to **\$53,500** in Indiana, **\$181,700** across the line in Illinois. Workers' comp is *upper* tier.
- **Unemployment insurance** reached fewer than **40 percent** of the unemployed in 2000. Upper tier.
- **Medicaid** spent about **\$10,000** per elderly patient in 2001. Medicare: about **\$6,000**. The lower tier outspends the upper.
- Americans hate "welfare." Ask about SSI, Medicaid, or food for the poor, and support runs about where Social Security's does (Gilens).

Howard's rule: if one of the Big Three doesn't fit the model, build a better model. **Verdict: reject the tiers.**

The flatline

- Official poverty rate, 1970: **12.6%**
- Official poverty rate, 2019: **10.5%**

Fifty years. And over that stretch, spending on the thirteen largest means-tested programs went from **\$1,015 to \$3,419 per person** — up 237%.

Desmond's chapter 2 walks the suspect list: stinginess, immigration, single parenthood. Each one fails the evidence.

But which number was that?

The official measure **never sees** SNAP, the EITC, housing help, or a stimulus check. Count those — the Supplemental Poverty Measure does — and poverty **falls meaningfully** over the same years.

Fantasy, in the film: *"I have received extra food stamps cause of COVID. That stimulus, that paid half my bills."*

The official measure records her as untouched.

Where the dollars leak

- **22 cents** of every budgeted TANF dollar reached families as cash in 2020. About \$6B sat unspent.
- Becky, in the film — approved for pandemic unemployment: *"Everything is still pending, though, so I haven't gotten anything yet."*
- Crystal — *"I am still required to work my hours for my assistance ... maybe my assistance could get shut down."*

And Howard's map: Crystal's household runs on food stamps, HUD, disability-linked cash, and free school lunch **at once** — four programs, both "tiers," one trailer.

Two books, one question

- **Howard:** the map you were handed doesn't describe the territory.
- **Desmond:** the money on the map doesn't all arrive.

So when Americans say they hate "welfare" — **which program are they picturing?** Is it even on Howard's map?

Due and next

- **Discussion Paper 1** — *Growing Up Poor in America*, both parts, with Howard ch. 3 and Pierson: **Friday 9/18**, 11:59 p.m., Canvas. Keep film notes now — a person, a scene, a moment.
- **Pre-survey**, if you missed it today: by **Friday 9/11**.
- **No paper on the CSU contract**. Nothing is due Tuesday 9/8.
- **Labor Day Monday 9/7 — no class**. Week 3 is **Wednesday 9/9 only**: Howard ch. 1, Desmond chs. 3–4.